‘We can’t be too sure, can we?’ she replied.

‘It’s all about being confident,’ Aditi said. ‘I’ve only shown them what they needed to see. There’s no chance I’m going back today without a yes.’

‘Such overconfidence!’ Hema couldn’t keep herself from commenting. Aditi rolled her eyes detestably. ‘If I can see it, surely they can too,’ Hema said to me faintly. ‘I can bet a wager on her rejection.’

I had my eyes fixed on the bulbs. As soon as the green one glowed, I’d be only one candidate away from my interview. I looked at my attire for the day—my pants and shirt were neatly ironed, my hair was tied in a tight bun. I cleared my throat. I was set. And as if on cue, the green light flashed.

As soon as the interviewee went inside, the light turned from green to red. My gaze was fixed on the bulb. It must have been less than ten minutes, but it felt like an eternity before the candidate came out. She seemed relaxed. After about another two minutes, the green bulb lit up again. I could feel my heart flutter as I stood up to go in. Hema wished me luck and I smiled back at her. I pulled open the door of the conference room and, just as I had imagined, I saw in front of me a panel of six officers sitting behind a rounded table. They were all familiar faces I had encountered during our various tests.

‘May I come in?’ I asked.

‘Please be seated,’ Wing Commander Pathak signalled. He was the interviewing officer (IO) I had seen during the PABT.

I seated myself on the edge of the chair, both my hands carefully folded on my lap. Sqn Ldr Yadav and Sqn Ldr Virk smiled at me. I was too nervous to smile back. The others were busy going through the files that had been kept in front of them. I guessed it was my personal information questionnaire form, which each of us had filled up on the first day of the SSB. I patiently waited for the IO to shoot the first question.

‘How was your SSB experience, Ms Saxena?’ he finally lifted his head and asked.

‘Informative, Sir,’ I replied at once, ‘and memorable.’

‘How many friends did you make here?’ he asked.